Bare is not the same as dead.

Opening the conversation

When you think about your church, what comes into view first: the people God has placed there, or everything that still isn't working?

It's easy for the unfinished work to take up the whole view. The same few people keep showing up. A ministry takes more effort than you expected. You care deeply about your community, but the relationships aren't coming as easily as you'd hoped.

So let's look again. Where are people praying faithfully? Who is growing in their walk with Jesus? Where is someone being loved who might otherwise be overlooked?

We need to see that life, too.

Bare is not the same as dead. What looks quiet may still have deep roots. That doesn't settle every question about the church. It gives us a reason to look carefully before we decide what needs to change.

The Heartbeat

Read John 15:1-17 together, giving particular attention to verses 1-5 and 9-17.

Jesus says, “Remain in me, as I also remain in you.”

John 15:4, NIV, excerpt.

He is speaking to His disciples about life in Him, bearing fruit, obedience, and love. Our work together begins there.

We want a church rooted in Christ, alive through the Holy Spirit, tended by the Father, and bearing fruit that reaches people with the saving grace of Jesus.

Systems do not create life. Jesus does. Healthy systems make room for the life He is already growing.

That is the conviction we bring to this work. Is the way we're doing ministry helping people live and serve faithfully, or are people spending all their strength keeping the activity going?

Walking through the image

Rooted. There may be more here than the surface shows. Listen to the faithful people. Hear the stories before deciding that little is happening.

Awakening. Notice the beginnings. Someone asks to learn. A strained relationship begins to mend. A neighbor trusts you enough to share a need. Those moments deserve attention, even before they become anything larger.

Walking through the image

Flourishing. People have room to grow, serve, and breathe. Responsibilities are clear. Help is available. Someone can say, “I can't carry that right now,” and be heard without being shamed.

Fruitful. Look at what is happening in people's lives. Are they following Jesus, growing in love, and serving their neighbors? Are people outside the church experiencing that love and hearing the good news of Christ? Attendance can tell us something, but it cannot answer all of those questions.

Multiplying. The life reaches beyond the people who started the work. Someone who was welcomed begins welcoming others. Someone who was equipped begins helping another person grow. Ministry becomes something people share.

This is a picture of seasons, not a scorecard. Different parts of the same church may look very different right now. We aren't trying to hurry every ministry toward the last tree. We want to understand what needs tending.

Questions worth sitting with

1. Where do we see the life of Christ in our church today? What stories help us see it?
2. Who has room to grow and serve, and who is quietly carrying more than they can sustain? Have we asked them?
3. Where are we loving people beyond our doors, and where do we need to listen before deciding how to serve?

Putting this into practice

Use a conversation the team already has scheduled. Choose one real example of life taking root and ask the people involved what is helping and what is getting in the way.

Pray together with Scripture open. If something needs attention, agree on one response and the support it requires. That might mean protecting something already working, sharing a responsibility, simplifying a process, or stopping something harmful. It doesn't have to mean starting another ministry.

If the work is healthy and the people carrying it have what they need, let it continue. No extra assignment is required to prove that the conversation mattered.

Moving into the next chapter

As we look for life in the church, the people carrying its leadership belong in the conversation too. Their faithfulness may be visible while the cost remains hidden.

Who knows the soul beneath the role?

That brings us to **A Pastor Can Be Known and Still Unsupported**.

Presenter notes

- Let people look at the visual before explaining it. Ask what they notice. Give them time to answer without correcting their first impression.
- Read the Scripture from a Bible. The short excerpt above is exact NIV wording; the rest of the sheet is our reflection and practical application, not rewritten Scripture.
- Use the five movements to invite stories, not to assign a church a maturity level. Neither small attendance nor a busy calendar settles the question of health.
- “Bare is not the same as dead” is a hopeful possibility, not a declaration that every struggling church or ministry is healthy. Neglect, wrongdoing, unsafe practices, and real exhaustion need an appropriate response; calling them a season does not excuse them. Do not delay necessary care until later chapters.
- Invite disagreement. Where authority or relationships could make an honest answer costly, offer a private way to contribute and explain confidentiality limits. Do not require a Pastor or volunteer to disclose personal struggles in the group.
- Do not treat the people in the picture as resources to harvest. Multiplication includes their formation, willingness, capacity, and care. Do not label overwork as sacrifice and make it untouchable.
- No Barna statistic has been added. This opening chapter establishes our understanding of life and health; research belongs where it helps the specific conversation rather than decorating every chapter.

Scripture and image boundaries

The tree landscape is our illustration, not Jesus' vine metaphor reproduced literally, and not a five-stage biblical model.

- **John 15:1-17:** Jesus identifies Himself as the vine and the Father as gardener. Read the connection between remaining, fruit, obedience, and love; do not turn pruning into permission to treat people as disposable.
- **John 7:37-39:** Jesus invites the thirsty to come to Him; John identifies the living-water promise with the Spirit. This informs “alive through the Holy Spirit,” not a mapping of the Spirit onto soil.
- **Matthew 13:18-23:** Jesus explains responses to the kingdom message. Good soil represents the hearer who receives and understands the word, not an organizational process or a member of the Trinity.
- **Mark 4:26-32:** These parables concern God's kingdom. They invite attention to beginnings and growth beyond human control; they do not promise a consulting process will produce numerical church growth.

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